Change-Order Cost Control Workbook

From a changed scope to a checked price and a traceable decision.

3 complete worked cases

6 reusable worksheets / 30 fillable fields

Credits, quantities, revisions, timing and invoice checks

For U.S. homeowners reviewing changes during an existing project. Hypothetical project amounts use USD; the store price is £9.99 GBP.

Your route through this workbook

Reader outcome: produce one change-review packet that connects baseline evidence, scope difference, net price, approval status, funding exposure and later billing. If evidence is missing, leave with precise provider questions rather than a false final number.

Read pages 3-13 for the method and three checked cases. Complete worksheets on pages 14-19. Copy the provider questions on page 20. Use page 21 for source boundaries and page 22 for the final review.

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This workbook does not authorize work, determine legal liability, provide a technical specification or replace a professional assessment. No customer trial, guaranteed savings or validated purchase demand is claimed.

One decision, one traceable record

Use this workbook when an existing project changes, rather than when choosing the original contractor. Your output is a review packet connecting the old scope, proposed difference, net price, timing, decision and later invoice. A change can be an addition, a deletion, a substitution or a correction. Recording only increases leaves credits invisible.

Bring the accepted contract and attachments, current change log, invoices, payment record and any provider assessment. Label every file with its date and revision. If you cannot identify the accepted starting scope, record that gap first. A workbook cannot establish what the parties agreed when the underlying evidence is missing.

The book is an owner planning aid, not a contract form, valuation service or instruction to proceed with work. It does not decide responsibility for concealed conditions or interpret your legal rights. Urgent safety concerns require qualified local help; do not delay an appropriate emergency response to finish paperwork.

All worked amounts are invented USD teaching scenarios, not market rates. The purchase price is separately £9.99 GBP. Worksheets are printable and interactive; fields do not calculate or upload data. Save a copy in a compatible PDF reader and reopen it to confirm your entries persisted.

Freeze the baseline before comparing

Give the original agreement a baseline ID. Record its price, tax treatment, scope version and attachments. Then list already accepted changes in approval order. Keep the original price unchanged: the current accepted contract amount is the original amount plus signed additions minus signed credits, according to the actual agreement.

Separate contract value from owner costs. Appliances purchased directly, temporary accommodation and independent professional fees may affect the household forecast without belonging in the contractor's contract. Mixing these totals makes it easy to charge the same item twice or mistake an owner expense for money owed to the contractor.

For each proposed change, write the exact baseline line it replaces or supplements. Attach the relevant paragraph, selection or drawing reference. If the contractor says an item was excluded, ask where the exclusion appears. If the owner believes it was included, record the evidence rather than labeling the new request free.

Do not resolve disputed responsibility by changing the budget cell. Keep a disputed amount visible and obtain appropriate advice. The baseline worksheet is a record of evidence and questions, not proof that a disputed charge is payable or unenforceable.

Split the request into priceable parts

Assign a change ID and distinguish the trigger from the requested work. 'Tile changed' does not identify whether the change involves material, setting labor, demolition, substrate, trim, delivery or disposal. Ask the provider to identify what is added, removed and retained, with quantities and units where relevant.

A substitution needs both sides of the bridge: the cost of the new scope and the credit for the superseded scope. If the old material is already ordered, record who can return it, the documented restocking fee and who keeps it. Do not invent a full credit when the agreement and supplier evidence do not support it.

Allocate each line to one change ID. Where two changes share a mobilization or delivery charge, ask whether the charge is per visit or per item and where it will be billed. Mark the shared cost once, with a reference from the other change. Unresolved shared costs remain questions rather than silent zeros.

Classify the amount as fixed, allowance, measured quantity times rate, or cost-based. Ask what evidence finalizes a provisional amount and when it will be reconciled. A neat total is not a fixed offer if quantity or supporting work remains undefined.

Build a net-price bridge

Use this sequence: added work less supported credits, plus specifically agreed fees, markup and tax treatment. Record what each percentage applies to. A markup on materials only differs from a markup on materials and labor; tax may apply on a different base. The arithmetic here demonstrates a stated assumption, not the tax treatment required in your jurisdiction.

Never add a tax or overhead line to a quoted total without checking whether it already includes that amount. Likewise, do not assume that a credit gets the same markup treatment as a new purchase. Ask for a written breakdown that reconciles to the change total and identify every inclusion before combining figures.

Check units, signs and rounding independently. Read a deletion as a negative amount, distinguish purchased units from installed units, and carry cents consistently. Recalculate the stated formula yourself or with a calculator. If your result differs, record the difference and ask for a corrected revision instead of choosing whichever number seems favorable.

Keep the revised quote and the superseded one. A changed total without a visible reason can conceal a scope change. The decision should reference the final provider revision, not a spreadsheet containing an earlier assumption.

Case 1: a substitution with a credit

Invented scenario: a tile substitution adds $1,280 of material and $360 of labor. The provider confirms a $900 credit for unused baseline material. The assumed agreement applies 10% markup to the net direct change and no additional tax or fee. These assumptions must be confirmed for a real project.

Direct increase = $1,280 + $360 - $900 = $740. Markup = $740 x 0.10 = $74. Net proposed change = $740 + $74 = $814. With a $24,000 baseline and no prior accepted changes, the revised contract would be $24,814 if this revision is properly accepted.

An incomplete request for $1,804 could result from adding 10% to the full $1,640 while omitting the $900 credit. The difference is $990 under these assumptions: the missing credit plus its associated markup. This example is an arithmetic diagnostic, not a finding of overcharging or a prediction of savings.

Before deciding, request the baseline allowance reference, evidence that the material remains returnable, the included labor tasks and the markup basis. If a $75 restocking fee is later documented, obtain a revised bridge and confirm its markup treatment. Do not simply subtract $75 from the credit without preserving the new assumption.

Keep approvals separate from exposure

Maintain four distinct states: proposed, awaiting clarification, accepted, and rejected or superseded. An internal owner preference is not an authorization. Record the parties' required approval evidence and refer to the actual agreement and applicable local requirements. Do not label a contractor's revised proposal accepted just because it arrived by email.

California CSLB describes written change orders signed by customer and contractor before a covered change. This is California-specific guidance, not a statement of every state's law. The FTC notes that contract requirements vary by state. Confirm the appropriate process with your local authority or qualified adviser before relying on a particular form. Sources: California CSLB and FTC, checked October 26, 2026.

Track pending exposure beside accepted value. A proposed $2,000 item may matter to your decision forecast while remaining outside the accepted contract total. Conversely, rejected items should leave the active exposure total but stay in the historical log. Never add a superseded quote and its replacement together.

Use an explicit next-action owner and date. 'Pending' without a named missing answer can remain unresolved until the invoice arrives. Write the question, who must respond and the document that will close it. None of these records determines whether payment may legally be withheld.

Case 2: quantities and linked costs

Invented scenario: a provider assesses an added repair quantity of 18 units at $42 per unit, plus $180 mobilization. The assumed agreement applies 8% markup to both lines, with no additional tax. A separate $450 finish-restoration allowance is not part of this contractor's change and remains an owner forecast item.

Repair amount = 18 x $42 = $756. Subtotal = $756 + $180 = $936. Markup = $936 x 0.08 = $74.88. Contractor change = $1,010.88. Including the separate $450 restoration scenario gives total household exposure of $1,460.88. Do not add the $450 to the contract ledger unless the accepted contractor scope actually includes it.

If the final verified quantity becomes 23 units under the same stated terms: 23 x $42 = $966; plus $180 = $1,146; plus 8% = $1,237.68. The increase over the 18-unit scenario is $226.80. A five-unit increase is therefore not merely $210 when that markup applies.

Ask how quantity is verified, which units are billable, whether the mobilization charge is shared with another change, and who restores finishes. The owner should not expose hazardous assemblies or perform technical assessment to populate this sheet. Use appropriate qualified evidence and retain the provider's final scope and quantities.

Connect timing without double counting

A change may alter procurement, inspection, access or a later trade's start date. Ask for the affected milestone and its dependency, not just 'three extra days'. Establish whether the stated days are working or calendar days, whether another delay overlaps, and which completion date the provider now expects.

Separate a contractor's schedule revision from your household scenario. Temporary living costs or storage may be owner expenses; the fact that you model them does not establish liability. Record daily or weekly assumptions and their evidence. Do not add two delay periods automatically when both affect the same calendar days.

Record the revised payment trigger, amount and due-date assumption. A change fitting the overall budget may still require cash earlier than planned. Compare dated available funds with dated commitments. This is a planning comparison, not borrowing advice or permission to replace the agreed payment process.

For a cost-based or uncertain change, ask when you will receive updated evidence and what decision is required before further commitment. Do not invent a binding spending cap in the worksheet. Ask a qualified adviser to address contractual protections where needed, while retaining an honest pending-exposure scenario.

Case 3: approved value versus forecast

Invented scenario: original contract $40,000. Accepted change C01 adds $814; accepted C02 credits $600. Current accepted contract = $40,000 + $814 - $600 = $40,214. A pending repair scenario of $1,460.88 is not accepted. Of that amount, $1,010.88 would belong to the contractor and $450 would be a separate owner cost if the scopes proceed as modeled.

The household base includes $2,500 of other owner costs, none overlapping the $450. Baseline household forecast = $40,214 + $2,500 = $42,714. Including the entire pending scenario once gives $44,174.88. Against a $45,000 planning ceiling, remaining scenario headroom is $825.12. The ceiling is an owner constraint, not a guarantee of sufficient funding.

Suppose $18,000 has been paid against the accepted contract. Its unpaid accepted balance is $22,214, before considering any disputed invoices or payment terms. A hypothetical $4,000 next contractor payment and $450 restoration payment require $4,450 in the same period; if only $3,500 is available then, the timing gap is $950 even though the total forecast remains below the ceiling.

Use three separate labels in your review: accepted contract $40,214; household forecast including pending scenario $44,174.88; period funding gap $950. Confusing these numbers can hide both uncertain scope and an immediate cash need. Confirm the dates and terms rather than treating this demonstration as an actual payment schedule.

Reconcile the invoice to the change

For each billed change, link the invoice line to the accepted change ID and revision. Compare scope, quantity, rate, credits, fees and taxes with that evidence. Record prior billing for the same line. A change can be correctly priced and still be counted twice across a progress invoice and a final invoice.

Keep contract value, billed value and paid value in separate columns. Billed-to-date less paid-to-date is not automatically the amount presently due: due dates, milestones, disputes and other agreed conditions must be reviewed. Similarly, an unpaid contract balance includes future work and does not by itself support an immediate invoice.

At closeout, mark each change as completed, awaiting evidence, credited, superseded or unresolved. Attach relevant provider confirmation and updated product or warranty records. The Mississippi board's consumer guide highlights scope detail, dates, permits and warranties in contract records; use local requirements and qualified review for your project. Source checked October 26, 2026.

If an invoice cannot be reconciled, send a neutral written question identifying the line and difference. Keep the response and the original invoice. The FTC recommends retaining notes and copies of communications in a dispute. For rights, remedies or payment disputes, seek appropriate local advice rather than relying on this workbook.

Run the review packet in one sitting

Start with one current change, not the entire renovation history. Complete the baseline and scope sheets, calculate the bridge, then update status and forecast. End with either a documented decision under the applicable process or a precise list of missing answers. 'Need more information' is a useful output when it names the evidence required.

Use the six reusable worksheets that follow. Each has five generous fillable areas and printable lines. Duplicate blank worksheet pages for personal project use, or save separate named copies per change. Label them with the same change ID. None of the fields runs formulas, and the worksheets are not an executable contract or signature platform.

Before forwarding a completed record, remove unrelated personal information and check attachments. The blank PDF does not send entries to HomeCostEngine. Sharing a saved copy with your own provider is your decision. Preserve your original unedited evidence so later reconciliation does not depend on a modified worksheet alone.

If you already own the Contractor Quote Comparison Playbook or the Renovation Budget Blueprint, you have introductory change and budget guidance. This focused workbook adds the replacement-credit bridge, quantity sensitivity, status controls, double-counting review and invoice matching. It is optional; do not buy it merely to obtain another general budget explanation.

Baseline and document register

Use one change ID throughout. Enter concise notes and evidence references; attach supporting records separately. Fields do not calculate.

Project / change ID / owner / review date

Original contract amount / tax status / baseline revision

Already accepted additions and credits / references

Current accepted value / independent arithmetic check

Owner-only costs / exclusions / unresolved baseline questions

Scope difference and credit map

Use one change ID throughout. Enter concise notes and evidence references; attach supporting records separately. Fields do not calculate.

Change ID / reason / triggering evidence

Baseline line being replaced / retained / added

Added quantities, units, materials, labor and restoration

Credit evidence / return conditions / shared-cost allocation

Missing technical assessment / responsible provider / next date

Net-price bridge

Use one change ID throughout. Enter concise notes and evidence references; attach supporting records separately. Fields do not calculate.

Change ID / quoted revision / fixed or provisional basis

Added work total / supported credits / net direct amount

Markup percentage AND exact base / tax inclusion

Fees / net total / independent calculation / discrepancy

Supporting documents / unanswered pricing questions

Revision and decision log

Use one change ID throughout. Enter concise notes and evidence references; attach supporting records separately. Fields do not calculate.

Change ID / revision date / superseded revision

Proposed / clarification / accepted / rejected status

Decision evidence and applicable approval process

Accepted addition or credit / pending exposure kept separate

Next action / person responsible / requested response date

Forecast and payment timing

Use one change ID throughout. Enter concise notes and evidence references; attach supporting records separately. Fields do not calculate.

Accepted contract / unpaid accepted balance / evidence

Owner costs outside contract / duplicates removed

Pending scenarios / excluded alternatives / assumptions

Dated commitments / available funds / period gap

Planning ceiling / scenario headroom / next review date

Invoice and closeout match

Use one change ID throughout. Enter concise notes and evidence references; attach supporting records separately. Fields do not calculate.

Invoice / change ID / accepted revision / billing date

Accepted line scope and total / billed-to-date / prior invoices

Paid-to-date / due-date conditions / disputed differences

Completion evidence / warranty and product records / credits

Open question / recipient / response / final disposition

Questions to send your provider

1. Which exact accepted baseline line does this change replace or add to?

2. What is removed, retained or credited, and where is the credit evidence?

3. Is this fixed price, an allowance, measured work or cost-based work?

4. What quantity, unit and verification method support the charge?

5. Which labor, access, protection, delivery, disposal and restoration are included?

6. Which markup and tax amounts are already included, and what bases apply?

7. Are any fees shared with other changes or already billed?

8. Which milestone changes, what dependencies apply, and do delays overlap?

9. What approval process applies here, and which revision will be accepted?

10. What payment trigger changes, and how will the invoice reference the change?

11. What updated records or warranties will be provided, and what remains unresolved?

Sources and boundaries

Primary sources checked October 26, 2026. Their guidance supports limited factual context; our arithmetic, decision sequence and worksheets are independently authored. No source endorses this book.

FTC: Written estimates, state variation and retaining dispute records; general consumer guidance.

https://consumer.ftc.gov/articles/how-avoid-home-improvement-scam

California CSLB: California-specific written, signed change-order guidance; not a nationwide rule.

https://www.cslb.ca.gov/Consumers/Hire_A_Contractor/Home_Improvement_Contracts/What_Is_A_Contract.aspx

Mississippi State Board of Contractors: Contract detail, payment schedule, dates, permit responsibility and warranties; local context.

https://www.msboc.us/wp-content/uploads/2026/03/CONSUMERS-GUIDE-TO-HOME-IMPROVEMENT-CONTRACTS.pdf

FTC informs the written-estimate and recordkeeping discussion. CSLB informs only the labeled California approval example. The Mississippi board guide informs the record categories in the invoice and handover discussion. Local requirements vary; verify the rules applicable to your home and agreement.

Overlap: existing HomeCostEngine general budget and contractor comparison books include introductory change concepts. No prose or worked case is copied from them here. The distinct output is an in-project change-review packet rather than initial quote selection. The related free article gives one checklist and one case; this book adds the full record set and two further cases.

Before you treat a number as final

Can another person find the baseline and the exact revision used? Keep source files unchanged and cross-reference the accepted evidence.

Does the net price include supported credits and each shared cost only once? Check the base of every percentage and the quoted tax treatment.

Have you separated accepted value, pending exposure, owner-only costs and payment timing? Do not mistake scenario headroom for cash available on a due date.

Is the required approval evidence complete under the actual agreement and local process? An owner worksheet is not a signed change order.

Can you match the next invoice to the accepted change and identify prior billing? Record open issues and seek appropriate help for disputes.

Save the completed PDF, close it and reopen it to test field persistence. Keep a blank master. Preview before printing and use actual-size printing if your reader scales pages unexpectedly.

Continue with the free companion checklist: https://homecostengine.com/blog/check-contractor-change-order-price . Keep the book only if its workflow is useful for your particular decision.